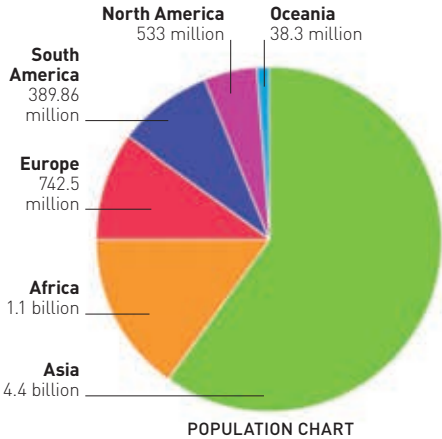


Our political world

There are 196 independent countries in the world today, all differing from each other in size, shape, population, language, government, and culture. The size of a country, its boundaries, and natural resources, such as oil and gas, are just some elements that affect both its internal organization and its relationship with other countries.

POPULATION

There are more than 7 billion people in the world today. United Nations' estimates of what the population will be in 2040 range from about 8 to 9.7 billion. Some areas of the world are more populated than others because of their climate, terrain, and natural and economic resources. Over half the world's population live in cities, most in Asia, as a result of mass migration from rural areas in search of jobs.



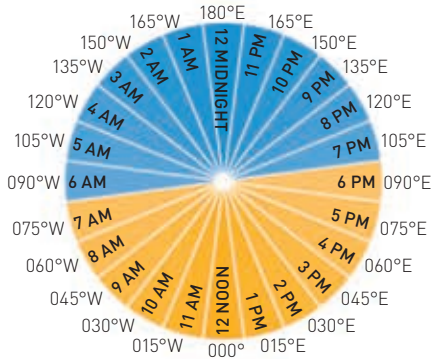
MEGACITIES

A megacity is an urban area with more than 10 million inhabitants. The top five megacities by population are in Asia.

- 1 TOKYO**
Japan: 37,843,000
- 2 JAKARTA**
Indonesia: 30,539,000
- 3 NEW DELHI**
India: 24,998,000
- 4 MANILA**
Philippines: 24,123,000
- 5 SEOUL**
South Korea: 23,480,000

TIME ZONES

The world is divided into more than 24 time zones. From the prime meridian (0° longitude), which runs through Greenwich, London, for every 15° you move west or east, you generally lose or gain an hour. At the equator a day is about 12 hours year round. Moving away from the equator, the day can increase to 24 hours or decrease to zero, depending on the time of year. Countries on similar latitudes have the same day lengths.



COUNTING TIME

The time zone change is counted at 15° intervals, because Earth rotates 15° each hour.

